

"Cambyases" for the Artaxerxes of I Esdr. 2:15 ff., could only do more harm than good. And the case with the history of the two great leaders, Ezra and Nehemiah, was no better, for *two* versions, incompatible with each other, were in circulation. The situation was an intolerable one, and could be ended only in one way, namely, by a new recension.

A final revision was accordingly made, and was officially adopted. The Story of the Youths was cut out bodily from the book, and care was taken that it should never again appear in the Jewish sacred writings. But unfortunately, in the excision of the Story, *a part of the Chronicler's original narrative was cut out with it.* The cause of this accident is easy to see. The expanded Story, as edited by the interpolator, did not end with I Esdr. 4:63, but extended through the first six verses of chap. 5. The interpolation in vs. 6, supported by the occurrence of the name "Darius" both here and in vs. 2, left the revisers no alternative; the knife must cut between vss. 6 and 7. Upon the excision of the Story followed necessarily the restoration of the Artaxerxes correspondence to its proper place.

The choice between the two versions of the Ezra-Nehemiah story must have caused more difficulty. What led the Jewish revisers here to follow Edition A rather than Edition B can only be a matter of conjecture. Possibly some external evidence showing that the order of chapters in the former was older than that in the latter was still in existence. But it is perhaps more likely that what decided the matter was the presence, through interpolation, of Nehemiah's name in the three doubtful chapters (see Neh. 8:9 and 10:1, and compare the date in 1:1), an interpolation which easily (and almost inevitably) took place after these chapters had been accidentally transposed into the story of Nehemiah.

So much for the origin of our canonical Ezra. As for our First Esdras, it is, as has already been said, the one surviving fragment of the old Greek version of the Chronicler's history, a version which was simply a faithful rendering of Edition B, and was probably made in the latter part of the last century B. C. The accompanying diagram will serve to illustrate the history of the two recensions.

The extent of our First Esdras, it is hardly necessary to add, is due simply to accident. Probably all the manuscripts, Semitic